

Julius Caesar: The Role of the Technical Adviser

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THERE ARE CLICHÉS and standard anecdotes about all categories of people in the film world, even about such a transient and marginal one as the "technical adviser" or "expert." The more obvious and banal stories have to do with money and are based on the common notion that the intellectuals' ranks from which experts are recruited are underpaid, whereas film salaries are high. The episodes that I have heard on the subject range all the way from the one about the producer of a historical motion picture who hired a professor as a period expert and, on offering to pay a certain figure, found that the professor understood it as a monthly salary while he himself had intended it, of course, as a weekly one; to the one about the medical expert who was summoned from a university to work as consultant on a tricky murder situation in a film, and after asking whether he might charge his "usual fee," mentioned a very substantial figure as his "daily" one. From then on, the story continues, he was highly respected by his temporary employers, put up in a splendid hotel suite, fetched by a studio Cadillac every morning, and so on.

The most significant stories, however, concern the actual work of an "expert." And they add up to the general idea that a "technical adviser" will be asked to produce detailed information in his field, that he will even be given an office and a stenographer at the studio, and that finally no use at all will be made of his expert advice.¹ This is the cliché. How completely inaccurate it is I can-

¹ Cf. Hortense Powdermaker, *Hollywood, the Dream Factory*, Boston, 1950, p. 27: "The position of the 'expert' who is called in for temporary consultation on a picture is frequently like that of the artist. He is usually paid a high fee, and then very little or no attention is paid to his opinion."